

TALENT DEVELOPMENT ENVIRONMENT OR PERSONALITY? PREDICTING CONTINUED SPORT PARTICIPATION FOLLOWING ATHLETE DESELECTION

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INTRODUCTION

Talent development pathways aim to support athletes' progression towards elite performance; however, only a small proportion of pathway athletes ultimately progress to senior elite performance. [1,2] Deselection can therefore represent a significant transition within an athlete's developmental pathway [3], with athletes experiencing varied trajectories following their exit from the pathway. [2,3]

Previous research suggests that experiences within talent development environments (TDEs) may influence athletes following deselection. [2] Personality traits have separately been associated with sport participation and athletic success [4], as well as adjustment to major life transitions such as retirement. [5] However, the relative contribution of environmental and personality characteristics to continued sport participation following athlete deselection remains unclear.

This study aims to determine the extent to which perceived talent development environment and Big Five personality traits predict continued participation in athletes' original sport following deselection.

METHODS

A retrospective, cross-sectional survey incorporating open-ended questions will recruit approximately 150-250 athletes, with the target sample informed by recommended events-per-variable considerations for logistic regression. [6] Eligible participants will have been previously involved in a recognised talent-development pathway, competing at a level consistent with Tier 3 (Highly Trained/National Level) of the Participant Classification Framework [7], and experienced deselection 1-5 years previously, to allow sufficient time for a post-deselection participation pattern to emerge.

Participants will complete the Talent Development Environment Questionnaire-5 (TDEQ-5) [8] and the Big Five Inventory-2 (BFI-2). [9] Background information will include current age, gender, sport, time since deselection, pathway level at deselection, and duration within the pathway. Open-ended questions will explore factors influencing continued or discontinued participation and participants' broader pathway experiences. The primary outcome, continued sport participation, will be operationalised as a binary

measure of whether participants continue to participate as an athlete in the sport from which they were deselected, with follow-up items describing level of participation (recreational/sub-elite/elite) and other forms of ongoing engagement (coaching, spectating) as descriptive context.

EXPECTED OUTCOMES AND ANALYSIS

Binary logistic regression will examine the relative contribution of perceived talent development environment and Big Five personality traits to continued sport participation, while accounting for relevant demographic and sporting covariates. Open-ended responses will be analysed using content analysis to provide contextual information alongside the quantitative findings. It is expected that both perceived talent development environment and personality characteristics will contribute to differences in continued sport participation following deselection, although their relative contribution remains to be determined.

SIGNIFICANCE

Most athletes who enter talent pathways will not reach elite level, yet little is known about what determines their continued relationship with sport once that pathway ends. This study directly compares environmental and personality-based explanations for continued sport participation following deselection, offering evidence that may help talent-development systems support athletes who do not ultimately progress to elite sport.

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